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MENTORSHIP SESSION

Is this a real rental listing or a scam?

Real cases, key red flags, and how Vonage technology helps us detect and prevent rental scams in Spain.

Video API
Live and interactive property viewings

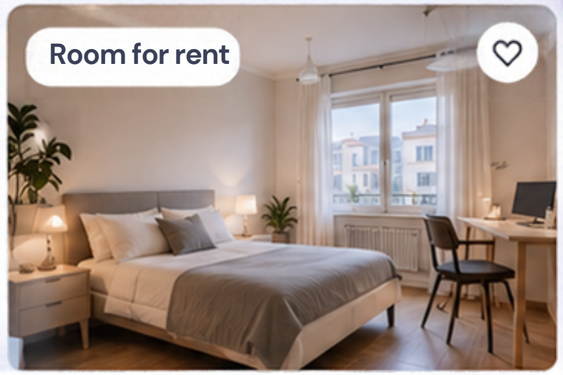
Verify API
Real identity and phone number verification

Messages API
Secure and traceable communication

CASE 1

The fake landlord in another city or with a fake contract

A common scam where the fraudster provides a realistic contract and asks for a deposit in advance, claiming there is a queue to visit the property.



Room in 100m – Center

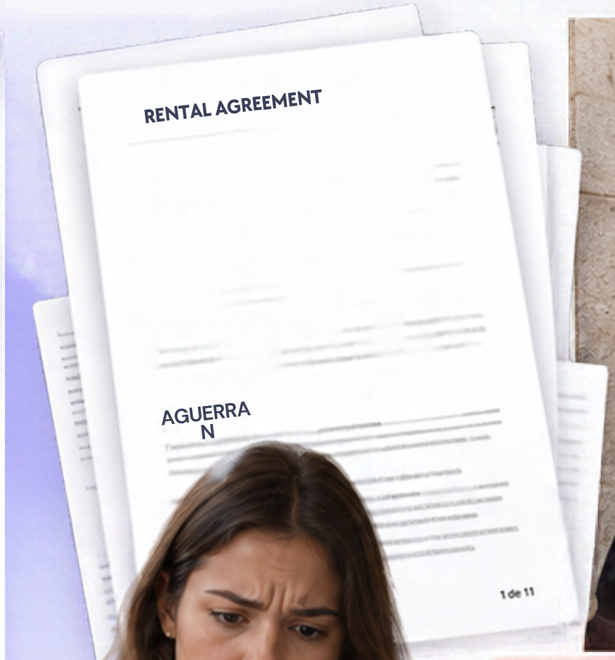
€500/month

1 room · 15 m² · Center

Bright room in a shared apartment.
Great location, available immediately.
Perfect for students.

Hi! There are many people interested. To secure it, you need to send a deposit today. I'm currently in another city, but I can send you the contract. 10:45

PDF **Rental contract.pdf** (11 pages) 10:46



She arrived at the building... **but the door did not exist.**

Real case

Antena 3 Notícias – "Estafas inmobiliárias de nueva generación está perfectamente diseñada para que cualquiera caiga"

HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

Vonage Video API

Live and interactive property viewing before any payment.

Vonage Verify API

Phone number verification and ownership check (Silent Authentication / OTP) to prevent fake accounts with disposable SIMs.

+34 612 345 678

Verification code: **482931**

CASE 2

The network of "ghost flats" with bargain prices across Spain

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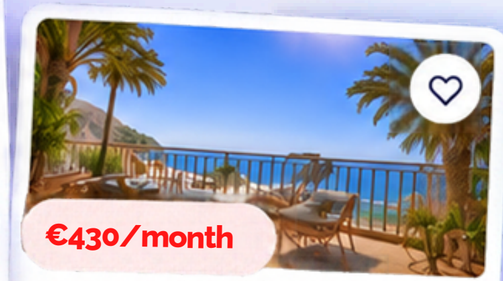
A fake "super-landlady" published dozens of identical listings with stolen photos in different cities (Ibiza, Granada, Estepona, etc.) at unusually low prices, asking for money in advance to "block the reservation".

€450/month

Apartment in Ibiza

2 beds · 70 m² · Ibiza



€430/month

Apartment in Estepona

2 beds · 75 m² · Estepona

€420/month

Apartment in Granada

2 beds · 68 m² · Granada

€460/month

Apartment in Madrid

2 beds · 72 m² · Madrid

Real case

Antena 3 Noticias – "The ghost flats scam: woman advertees properties that aren't hers and keeps the money".

HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

1 Vonage Verify API

Detection of virtual numbers (VoIP) or temporary SIMs used at scale to create multiple fraudulent identities.

+34 612 345 678

Virtual number detected

Line type	VoIP (not a real mobile)
Fraud risk	High
Ownership verification	Not verified

2 Vonage Messages API

Secure and traceable communication within the platform, preventing the scammer from moving the conversation to anonymous channels (WhatsApp / SMS) outside the controlled environment.

All messages are handled through the platform. Never accept links or payments outside of here.

CASE 3

Impersonation of real estate agencies on listing platforms

Scammers clone the logos and names of legitimate agencies, publish real photos, schedule fake viewsings and ask for a deposit in advance before cutting off all communication.

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Verified agency

€1,200/month

2 beds | 85 m² | Madrid

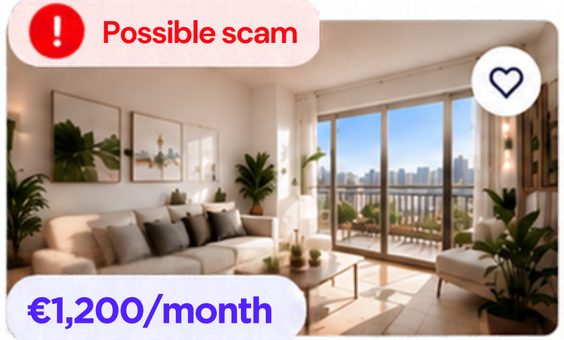
Bright apartment in Salamanca

Recently renovated apartment, exterior, with elevator. Managed by a real estate agency.

Inmobiliaria Real Estate
Real estate agency

View profile

Possible scam



€1,200/month

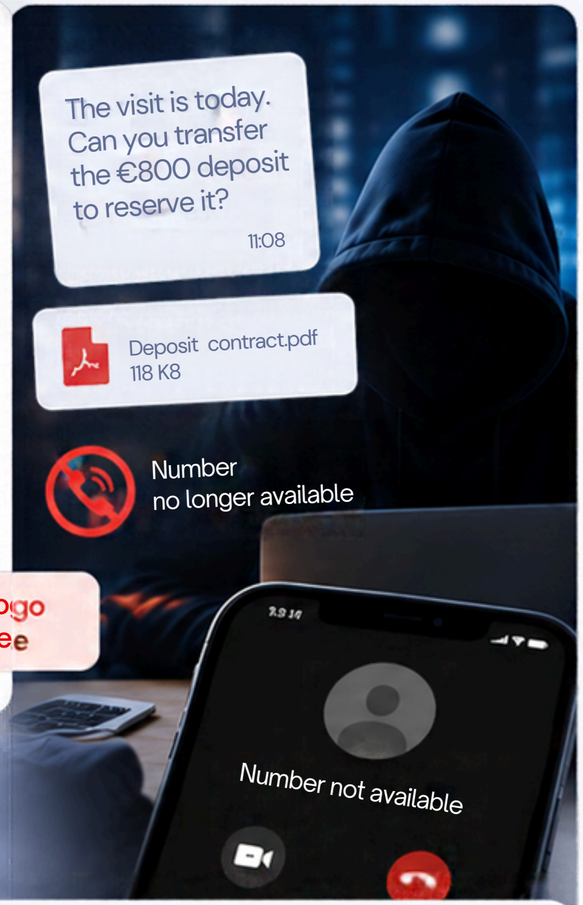
2 beds | 85 m² | Madrid

Bright apartment in Salamanca

Recently renovated apartment, exterior, with elevator. Managed by a real estate agency.

Inmobiliaria Real Estate
Real estate agency

Closed logo and name



Multiple identical listings in different cities using the same fake identity.

HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

1 Vonage Video API

Authenticated video call with the agent or property manager, showing their professional accreditation, with a temporary watermark and session recording.

PROFESSIONAL ACCREDITATION

Real Estate Agent

Vonage Verify API

Strict validation of the agent's corporate phone number using ownership verification, Silent Authentication or OTP.

+34 612 345 678

- Real and verified number
- Assigned to the agency
- Prevents disposable SIMs and fraudulent accounts

CASE 4

Deposit scam through cloned links (Phishing)

The fake landlord claims to be abroad and sends a link by email or SMS, pretending to be Airbnb or Booking, to hold the property. The link leads to a cloned website where they steal the victim's banking details.

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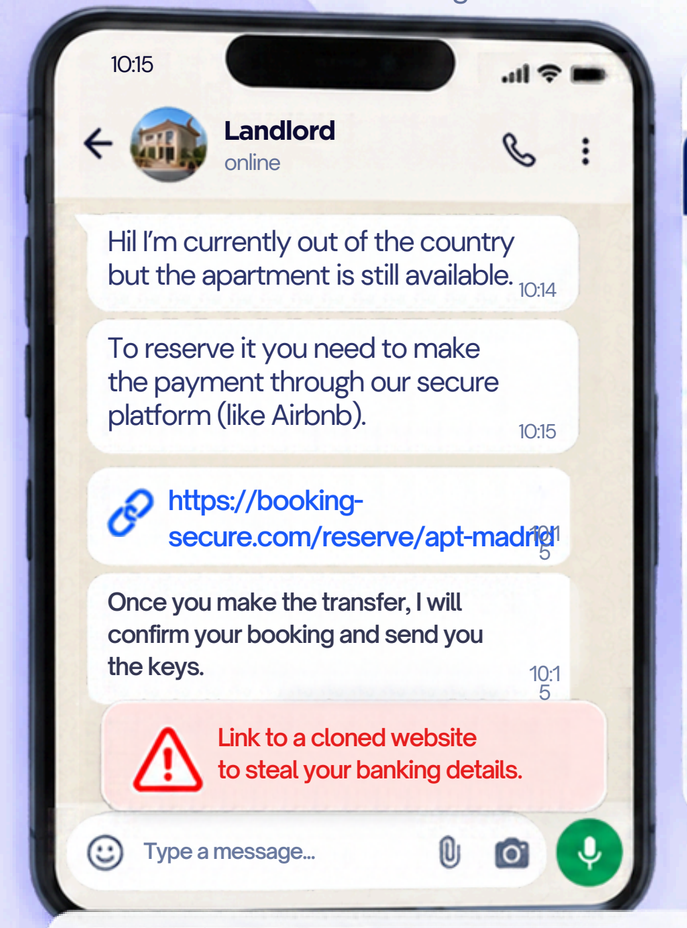

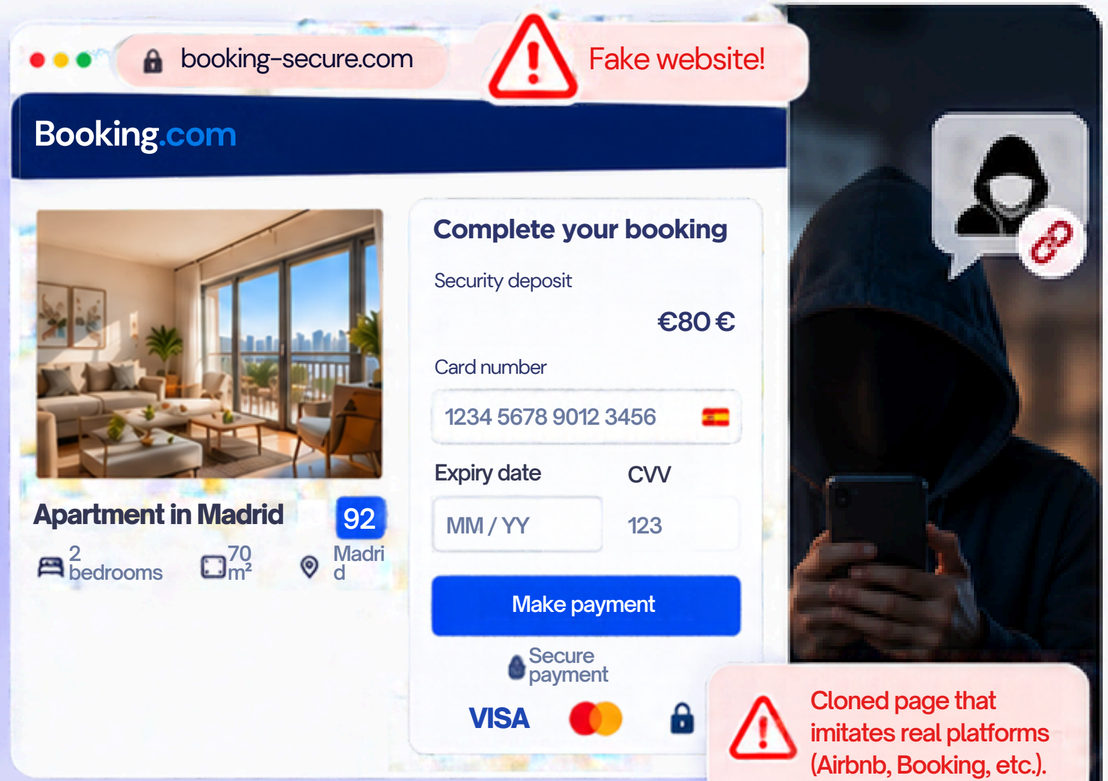

Cloned page that imitates real platforms (Airbnb, Booking, etc.).

HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

1 Vonage Messages API

Secure and traceable transactional communications within the platform, avoiding that users open fraudulent links from unverified senders.

VONAGE — Now

Your booking is managed only through our platform. Do not make payments or open links outside the app.

2 Vonage Verify API

Two-factor authentication (Silent Authentication) to confirm the identity of the advertiser and ensure that payment instructions are sent only through the official platform.

+34 612 345 678

- Real and verified phone number
- Linked to the advertiser
- Prevents disposable SIMs and fraudulent accounts

incibe SPECIAL SPECIAL CREDIBILITY INSTITUTE

Real case

INCIBE – Rental fraud:
The landlord sends a link pretending to be Airbnb or Booking to steal the victim's banking details.

CASE 5

Viewings that don't exist

The scammer schedules a viewing, but at the last minute they can't attend and ask you to send a link to "friend" or "family member" without proper identification. The person who shows up has no real access to the property or is not the owner, and the apartment actually belongs to someone else.

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Verified viewing

- Live video tour inside the property
- Comparison with the advertiser's verified identity
- Match between the property and the listing details

Matches the listing

HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

1 Vonage Video API

Guided live video viewing inside the property, with the advertiser or their representative, before any financial commitment.

2 Vonage Verify API

Identify and phone number verification (ownership / Silent Authentication / OTP) to ensure that the person managing the viewing is real.

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- Verified advertiser
- Real and confirmed phone number
- Reduces fake viewings and impersonation

Real case

La Vanguardia – Rental scams: people posing as owners to show apartments that aren't theirs.

CASE 6

Fraudulent sale of the same off-plan property / villa

Scammers sell the same property to multiple buyers, charging initial payments of over €60,000 for homes that are never built or are already committed to other buyers.

Notarial signing and confirmation by video Recording...

Signed document and recorded session

Villa_purchaseContract.pdf
2.4 MB

Two-factor verification of all signers

+34 123 345 678

SMS code
4 7 2 9 1 6

Real case

RTVE – Homeless and without money: victims of a real estate scam

Developers and intermediaries sold the same house to multiple buyers (in many cases foreigners) in Busot and other developments on the Costa Blanca.

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HOW OUR SOLUTION PROTECTS

1 Vonage Video API

Notarial or online property manager signing and confirmation via real-time video, with session recording in the cloud to provide legal evidence of the declaration of intent and the construction status.

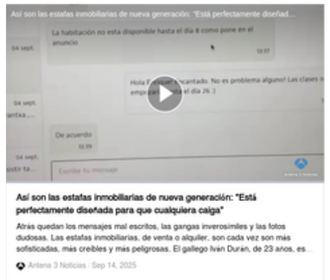
- Secure video call with notary or property manager
- Session recording in the cloud
- Legal evidence of the signature and property information (status, permits, etc.)

2 Vonage Verify API

Mandatory 2FA identity verification of all signers before issuing any payment order or certification.

- Verified identity (real phone number)
- One-time password (OTP)
- Prevents fraudulent payment orders and impersonation

These are not hypothetical cases. It has happened in Spain.



The flat that didn’t exist.

A student received an 11-page contract and was asked to pay a deposit. Upon arrival, they discovered that the door didn’t exist.

The network of ghost flats.

A fake owner listed homes that weren’t theirs in several cities and collected reservations in advance.

Impersonated real estate agencies.

Scammers used the names and logos of real agencies to request deposits for homes.

A house sold multiple times.

Buyers on the Costa Blanca lost large sums on fraudulent developments.

Documented Cases

Estafas al alquilar un piso, más comunes y cómo detectarlas

Te contamos cuáles son las estafas al alquilar un piso más comunes que se suelen dar, cómo detectarlas y cómo protegerte de ellas.

Homming / Oct 14, 2025

The fake owner of a holiday apartment

A scammer rents out a holiday property, pretends to be the owner, and collects deposits for a long-term rental.

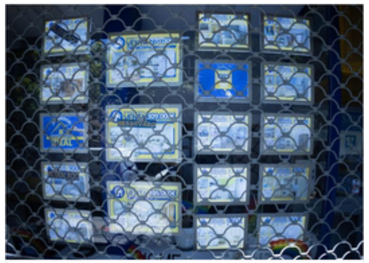
Homming

Sin casa y sin dinero: víctimas de una estafa inmobiliaria

RTVE.es / Mar 27, 2023

A house sold multiple times

Buyers on the Costa Blanca lost more than €60,000 on housing developments that were never built or had already been committed to other buyers.



Cuatro detenidos de dos inmobiliarias de Alicante por estafar a clientes en la compra de viviendas

ALICANTE (EFE).- Tres hombres y una mujer de entre 25 y 42 años empleados de dos inmobiliarias han sido detenidos en Alicante por supuestamente formar parte de...

Alicante Plaza / Feb 23

Fraudulent real estate intermediaries

In Alicante, employees of real estate agencies were arrested on suspicion of fraud involving contracts, unreturned deposits, and buyers' funds.

The scammer who collected multiple deposits

A man was convicted in Tenerife for collecting deposits of up to €1,940 from different families for homes he never delivered.

El Día https://www.eldia.es/sucesos/tribunales/2026/10/19/condenado-anos-carcel-tres-estafas-135504565.html

SECURE-PROPERTY-VIEWING

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Summary of Vonage integration in our project

How we use Vonage APIs to prevent the most common real estate scams.

Fraud vector	Risk	Vonage module that mitigates it
01 **Ghost listing / Fake identity** Advertiser using a disposable number or bot.	**Unverified advertiser** Hard to know if the person is real or using a temporary number.	**Vonage Verify API** Silent Authentication / SMS OTP to prevent SIM swap and verify real identity.
02 **Non-existent property / Stolen photos** The property does not match the listing.	**Property misrepresentation** Photos are fake or from another property.	**Vonage Video API** Live interactive virtual viewing to confirm the property exists and matches the listing.
03 **Phishing / Redirection to external channels** Sending malicious links or requesting payments through non-official channels.	**Fraudulent links and payments** Users are redirected to unsafe websites or asked to pay through opaque channels.	**Vonage Messages API** Verified notifications in-app and via WhatsApp Business to keep communication secure and traceable.
04 **Multiple sales or fake deposits** Lack of traceability and double reservations.	**Multiple buyers or fake deposits** The same property is sold or reserved to several people.	**Vonage Video API + Verify API** Notarial/agent signing and consent verification via video, with mandatory 2FA for all signers before issuing any payment order or certification.

SECURE-PROPERTY-VIEWING

Screen map and user flows for Peephole

A real estate agency in Catalonia. Two main journeys, one secure platform.
MVP focused on property visits and listings, powered by Vonage APIs.

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Vonage APIs used

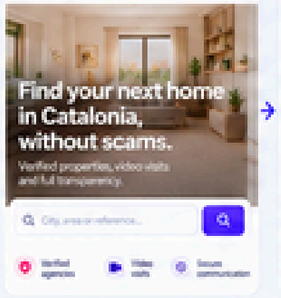
- **Video API** — Live and interactive property visits
- **Verify API** — Phone number verification (OTP)
- **Messages API** — Confirmations, reminders and alerts

JOURNEY A — Visitor

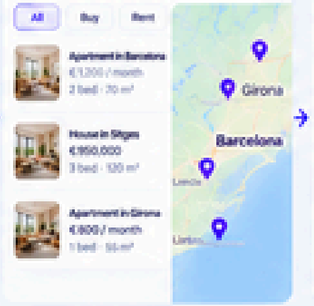
I want to visit a property

No registration. Phone number verification.

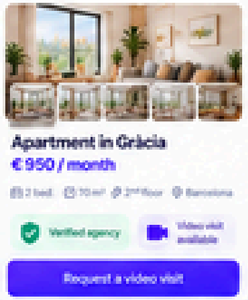
1. Home



2. Property catalog + Map

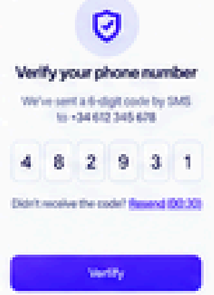


3. Property details

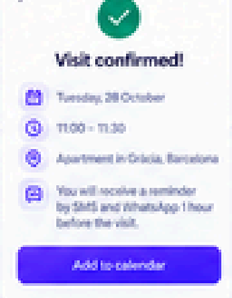


4. Select date and time

5. Phone verification



6. Confirmation



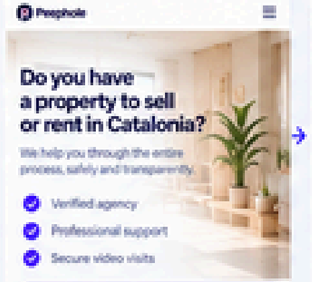
7. Video visit

JOURNEY B — Property owner

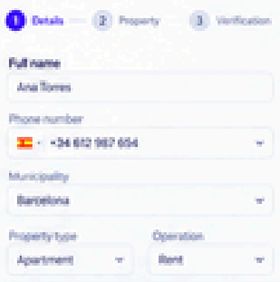
I want to list my property

Phone verification and video call with the agency.

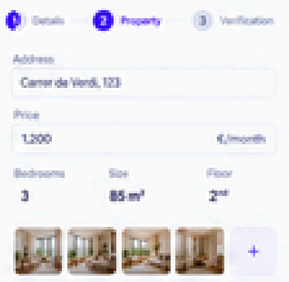
1. List my property



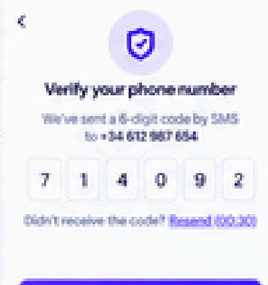
2. Owner information



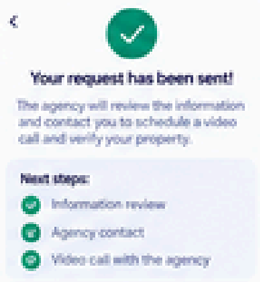
3. Property details



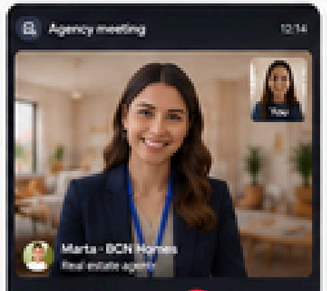
4. Phone verification



5. Request submitted



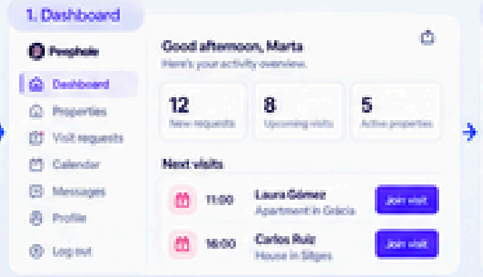
6. Video call with the agency



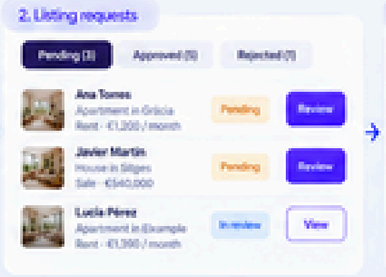
Agency dashboard

Manage properties, requests and visits.

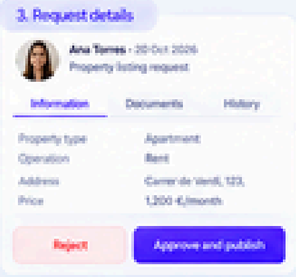
1. Dashboard



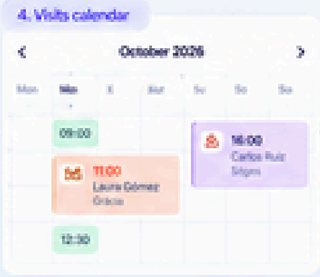
2. Listing requests



3. Request details



4. Visits calendar



5. Messages and notifications